

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

The Gospel of Life ~ An Endless Process of Becoming
September 7th, 2025



In the Beginning - Paul Klee 1916

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on KINGSFOLD and HYMN TO JOY

Élévation from *Messe Basse*, Op. 30 (Louis Vierne) and Improvisation

Three movements by Giovanni Battista Pergolesi

– Andante amoroso in C minor

– Allegro in Eb Major

– Allegro in G minor

Carillon de Westminster (Louis Vierne)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz & Yulia Fox

We live our lives with little regard
for the import of each moment.
They come to us
in regular and rapid succession,
and we live through each of them into the next.
A simple, ongoing process
into which our lives are set at birth
and through which we will proceed unto our deaths.

Yet in each moment resides incredible power –
new life, healing, opportunity,
and we, who move near-blindly through them
look to one another as we gather,
that we may do together
the work of opening one another
to the mysteries of this life,
and our potential of living to the fullest.

Today, may our singing be filled with transformation,
may our words reflect the yearning of our hearts,
and may the Spirit of Life that builds within us as we gather,
hallow each and every passing moment
we know here together.

In expectation of what shall be,
we ask all of this.

[adpt/vosper]

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Listen, Now We Tell a Mystery

HYMN TO JOY

Listen, now we tell a mystery, told by prophets long before;
We will all be changed forever; pain and death will be no more.
With the Spirit's healing power faith becomes reality;
We proclaim immortal glory far beyond what we can see.

Sound the transformation trumpet; sing a song of victory;
Heaven and earth join in the chorus, welcoming new liberty.
Ever changing, ever growing, we claim all we're meant to be,
Joining in the Spirit's work of setting all creation free.

Celebrate new life eternal, springing from Creative Love;
Resurrection brings rejoicing all around us and above.
With the liberating Spirit, we will soar on angel wings,
Ever onward, ever forward, as the world in triumph rings.

Lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

O Holy Presence,
You who are always becoming, always unfolding—
We come before you as unfinished people.
We don't have all the answers. We don't need them.
But we long to live in your way:
with mercy, with courage, with humility.

Keep us tender when the world hardens.
Keep us honest when power tempts.
Keep us generous when fear narrows our hearts.
Let us walk the path of becoming,
and never mistake it for arrival.
Amen and amen. [Cameron Trimble, adapt. ML]

***Introit**

"Pure Imagination"

LESLIE BRICUSSE & ANTHONY NEWLEY

Cathedral Choir, Commonwealth, and First Kids First, Brandon Harris, *Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Yulia Fox

Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Life shines out at us from even the shadowed corners
beckoning us to be drawn into its truth.

*With classic precision,
the options for peace are placed before us.*

We hesitate, laugh at the possibilities,
shrug off the responsibilities
and go about our merry way,
happy to leave whatever
those shadows may have brought.

In this hour, we turn toward those corners,
we sink into their deep mysteries,
open ourselves to life's possibilities,
yearn after its truths,
and notice, feel the weight of, and accept the responsibility
life has placed upon us.

*We are called to perceive with hearts that are open,
to listen with spirits attuned to truth,
and to live with a deep sense of purpose.*

This morning, may the heart of peace be with you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Children's Conversation

Claire Kelly

Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming. If you were unable to check your children in prior to the service, please accompany them to our Children's Area and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be picked up after worship before you head to Coffee Hour.

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
From Psalm 90

Yulia Fox

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

That truth has been inscribed into my heart
and into the heart of every human being,
there to be read and revered,
thanks be to you, O God.

That there are ways of seeing and sensitivities of knowing
hidden deep in the palace of the soul,
waiting to be discovered,
ready to be set free,
thanks be to you.

Open our senses to wisdom's inner promptings
that we may give voice to what we hear in our souls
and be changed for the healing of the world,
*that we may listen for truth in every living soul
and be changed for the well-being of the world.*
Amen and amen.

J. Phillip Newell, Prayer for Wisdom

Meditation Anthem

"The Flower Duet"

CLÉMENT DELIBES

Tiffany Ho and Christin Byrdson, *Soloists*

"Under the thick dome where the white jasmine with the roses entwined together on the river bank covered with flowers laugh in the morning, let us descend together! Gently floating on its charming waves in the river's current, one hand reaches for the bank. Here the spring sleeps, and the birds sing. Let us descend together!"

Sermon

An Endless Process of Becoming

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Joy Never Leaves"
Cathedral Choir

CHRISTOPHER HARRIS

"I am full of tears!! Tears of joy that seem to well and flow upon the thought that I carry the promise of beauty for ashes and life anew. A plan so delicate that no gentle hand of ours could place it all in place with grace to cause it not to break. Birthed from faith and made with love, it grows. Hope nurtures it and peace sustains the dwelling place as the hymn does the soul that sings of Thee. These tears which once fell for loss, now build a grateful river that runs through forests of prayer and possibility. They flow, but joy never leaves."
~Devondra Banks

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Yulia Fox

For all that has been, for that is, and for all that will be,
we give you our thanks, O God.

May these gifts be used to nurture the life
around us and among us,
as our lives grow
by the generosity of our hands,
and your love is made visible.

May it ever be so.
Amen and amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Mysteries, Yes

Rev. Lehman

Truly, we live with mysteries too marvelous
to be understood.

How grass can be nourishing in the
mouths of lambs.
How rivers and stones are forever
in allegiance with gravity
while we ourselves dream of rising.
How two hands touch and the bonds
will never be broken.
How people come, from delight or the
scars of damage,
to the comfort of a poem.

Let me keep my distance, always, from those
who think they have the answers.

Let me keep company always with those who say
'Look!' and laugh in astonishment,
and bow their heads.

-Mary Oliver

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Swimming To The Other Side"
Cathedral Choir

PAT HUMPHRIES, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***Hymn for the Journey**

How Deep the Silence of the Soul

KINGSFOLD

How deep the silence of the soul that lives within your grace.
How full the gratitude of heart in your abiding place.
What rich serenity is found, what courage and release
when Wisdom teaches us to seek the gentle path to peace.

Like unseen chimes on moving air, like warm and morning sun,
Like glad-dening, green-ing, grow-ing things, like trees with blooms begun.
Such is your presence in our lives, you touch without a trace,
until we turn and find ourselves held fast in your embrace.

-Lyrics by Sylvia Dunstan, UCC Hymnal

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Carillon de Westminster - Reprise (Louis Vierne)

Inside The Music

“ I like to think of the act of becoming as a personal invitation to myself. We know from neuroscience research that our brains predict everything we think, feel, and do and begin action before we are consciously aware of it. So much of becoming centers on increasing our awareness of those predictions, and encouraging ourselves to create new ones that align with our goals. The music today speaks to awareness in different ways. One of my favorite songs, “Pure Imagination” invites us to remember that everyone lives in a world of their own making. When we realize that we imagine the world around us, we can begin to join with others with open, curious minds. I love how the melody leaps regularly into moments of pause. These leaps are curiosity wrapped in whimsy teasing the ear into possibility. The famous “Flower Duet” from the opera “Lakme” embodies this invitation. A perfect spring day, the flowers blooming, the water flowing easily, the day calling us into being awaits two friends as they wander through their day seeking connection. Their awareness peaked by nature, they descend into togetherness. The music moves from moments of dialogue into and out of the melody that most people know as the song. That melody seems to float like the cool stream, fragrant like the flowers surrounding the friends. You can feel the day opening before them as the music envelops the space. Christopher Harris’ “Joy Never Leaves,” set to Devondra Banks’s poem, illuminates this experience from a perspective of renewal. “I am full of tears of joy” it says, “that I carry the promise of beauty for ashes and life anew.” We are cyclical beings caught in our limiting belief that we are linear. His music is full, robust, and complex. Yet, it sounds and feels simple, cutting, and freeing. In the end and after a harmonic exploration surrounding Bank’s intense examination, the music builds into chords of release on the words “they flow!” The movement of energy, in this case through tears, is the reminder that we are ever changing into the selves we will become.” – Dr. David Harris